INTERNATIONAL UNIVERSITY OF
VIETNAM NATIONAL UNIVERSITIES-HCM CITY - VIETNAM
SCHOOL OF BIOMEDICAL ENGINEERING
"High Quality – Sustainability – Usefulness"

LETTER OF SUPPORT

To: Sydney Vietnam Institute Seed Grant
RE: Huong Thi-Thanh HA

June 25th, 2025

To Whom It May Concern,

I am Nguyen Thi Hiep, Dean of School of Biomedical Engineering at the International University (IU). I am writing this letter to strongly support Dr Huong Ha, who is applying for Sydney Vietnam Institute Seed Grant. Huong is a devoted faculty member in our School and a member of the International University, Vietnam National Universities in Ho Chi Minh City (VNU-HCM).

For your information, VNU-HCM is one of the two leading public university networks in Vietnam. It was established in 1995 by grouping the elite public universities in the city. IU was established in 2003 as a platform to promote the reform of higher education in Vietnam. It is the first public university that teaches all courses in English. It has extensive collaborations with many universities in Australia, New Zealand, Thailand, Malaysia, Singapore, the United Kingdom and the United States of America. At IU, there are more than 10.000 students and 500 faculty members. The School of Biomedical Engineering Department (BME) at IU was established in 2009 as a department of IU before it became a school in 2019. It is the first in the country that offers the accredited degree of Engineer in BME (an equivalent of the BS BME in the U.S.) and the accredited Master's and Ph.D. degrees in BME. In 2015, ASEAN University Network Quality Assurance (AUN-QA) ranked our program first in Vietnam and 2nd in ASEAN among all programs in science, engineering, business and humanity assessed at that point in time. In Sep, 2019, our program obtained the accreditation from ABET, an American-based educational quality assessment organization and in 2024, our master training program obtained the accreditation from ASIIN.

When Huong returned to Vietnam for career establishment, I was really impressed by how passionate she was about her goal of dedication to the neuroscience community in Vietnam. As the Dean of the School of Biomedical Engineering at the time, I fully supported her application to our School. Working with her for many years gave me a firsthand perspective on her remarkable abilities. Starting as a freshly graduated PhD, she formulated research goals and executed projects with innovative ideas aimed at addressing specific challenges faced by the Vietnamese population. During her tenure at BME, she spearheaded diverse research projects spanning neuroscience. These included developing a web-based platform for automated Alzheimer's disease diagnosis, exploring Brain-Computer Interface systems using motor imagery for stroke rehabilitation, collaborating on a point-of-care device for quantifying cortisol (a stress marker) and investigating its effects on emotional responses. Huong's research extended beyond the lab, fostering collaborations between universities, companies, and hospitals in and outside Vietnam. She actively built connections with neurologists and pathologists across various departments at the University of Medicine and Pharmacy in Ho Chi Minh City, the 175 Military Hospital, Nguyen Tri Phuong Hospital and the April 30th Hospital. Leveraging her reputation, Huong secured a long-term collaboration with EMOTIV Inc., gaining support for her research on EEG-based diagnosis of stress and Alzheimer's disease.

In summary, Huong's exceptional academic record, including her selection as a Stanford Neuroscience graduate student and numerous prestigious awards, is a testament to her remarkable abilities. Her expertise in neuroscience, particularly in utilizing artificial intelligence and other cutting-edge technologies to address Alzheimer's disease in low-middle-income countries, perfectly aligns with the collaborative research focused on aiding patients in Vietnamese areas. I have unwavering confidence in Huong's leadership and wholeheartedly support her in leading this project to success. Please do not hesitate to contact me if you need any further information.

With best regards,

Thi-Hiep NGUYEN, PhD.
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Dean,
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Hoan Thanh NGO, PhD.

Assistant Professor of Computer Science and Engineering at Florida Southern College, Florida, USA

SYDNEY VIETNAM INSTITUTE SEED GRANT

RE: Huong Thi-Thanh HA

June 25th, 2025

To Whom It May Concern,

It is my great pleasure to write this letter of support and commitment for Dr. Huong Ha, who is applying to Sydney Vietnam Institute seed grant for research funding.

I am Ngo Thanh Hoan, Assistant Professor of Computer Science and Engineering at Florida Southern College. My expertise lies in artificial intelligence applications within medical diagnostics and healthcare technology, particularly in leveraging machine learning and deep learning for innovative healthcare solutions.

With my experience in developing AI-driven diagnostic tools, I am delighted to express my support for the proposed project focused on developing a speech protocol and database for early detection of Alzheimer's disease (AD) and mild cognitive impairment (MCI). My research expertise directly aligns with this project's objectives. Specifically, my work on signal processing and artifact removal in biomedical signals will be crucial for ensuring high-quality speech data acquisition, particularly important when working with elderly patients who may have various speech impediments or background noise challenges. Furthermore, having worked on point-of-care low-cost diagnostic solutions, I deeply understand the importance of developing tools that are not only accurate but also practical for deployment in diverse healthcare environments, particularly in rural Vietnam where access to specialized neurological care may be limited.

I have been impressed by Mrs. Huong's dedication to improving early detection of cognitive decline, and I believe that early detection through accessible, non-invasive methods like speech analysis can significantly improve patient outcomes and quality of life. I look forward to contributing to this important study that has the potential to transform how we detect and manage dementia in aging populations.

Sincerely,

Hoan Thanh NGO, PhD.

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Military Hospital 175
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Nghia Tien-Trong HOANG, MSc, M.D.

Head of Neurology Department, Military Hospital 175

SYDNEY VIETNAM INSTITUTE SEED GRANT

RE: Huong Thi-Thanh HA

June 25th, 2025

To Whom It May Concern,

It is my great pleasure to write this letter of support and commitment for Dr. Huong Ha, who is applying to Sydney Vietnam Institute seed grant for research funding.

I am Hoang Tien Trong Nghia, Head of the Neurology Department at Military Hospital 175. My work requires daily interaction with dementia patients, and I understand the hardships of early detection of dementia in Vietnam, especially in rural areas. I believe with my experiences working in Neurology, I can contribute a clinical aspect to the project and help Mrs. Huong in recruiting dementia patients, communicating with them, and developing speech strategies to identify patients living with dementia in the medical records to understand how their cognitive care needs and experiences of care differ from those of individuals of similar age and backgrounds who do not have a dementia diagnosis. Furthermore, Military Hospital 175's extensive network of physicians and healthcare professionals enables the research project to access diverse patient populations from urban and rural areas, ensuring that the research findings are applicable to a broad spectrum of patients with varying demographic and socioeconomic backgrounds. The doctors will assist the project in recruiting dementia cohorts from urban and rural areas, facilitating the collection of necessary data from patients and caregivers.

We are collaborating on several projects, including an intervention application for patients with mild cognitive impairment. In addition, we are also actively involved in developing the Brain-Computer Interface, which can enhance the recovery of motor function in stroke patients. Our hospital is providing soundproof rooms and assisting with patient recruitment and cognition assessment, thereby playing a critical role in the support of this project. Furthermore, our hospital is totally dedicated to the advancement of the integration of clinical practice and research. We are consistently getting ready to supply the necessary human resources, including highly qualified physicians, to guarantee the success of our collaborative endeavors. Throughout our work together, I have been deeply impressed by Mrs. Huong's unwavering dedication, kindness, and sincerity towards her objectives. As we discussed, we both realized that early care is vital in enhancing the quality of life for those affected by dementia. We acknowledge that with the proper care and support, dementia patients can lead fulfilling lives, and we are responsible for ensuring they receive the attention they deserve.

Sincerely,

Nghia Tien-Trong Hoang, MSc, M.D.
Head of Neurology Department, Military Hospital 175
Address: 786 Nguyen Kiem, Ward 3, Go Vap District, Ho Chi Minh city.

June 25, 2025

RE: Letter of Support for Dr Huong Thi-Thanh Ha – Sydney Vietnam Institute Seed Grant

To Whom It May Concern,

I am writing to express my full support for Dr Huong Thi-Thanh Ha's application for the Sydney Vietnam Institute Seed Grant.

My name is Dr Halle Quang, and I am a Postdoctoral Research Fellow at the Brain and Mind Centre, The University of Sydney. My research focuses on cross-cultural neuropsychology, dementia, traumatic brain injury, and neuroimaging. In particular, I investigate the neuropsychological outcomes of traumatic brain injury and dementia, with a focus on cognitive changes and apathy. I am also committed to advancing neuropsychological assessment for Vietnamese populations by validating and adapting culturally appropriate clinical tools.

Given my background in ageing and dementia research, I am pleased to support Dr Ha's proposed project to develop a speech-based protocol and database for the early detection of Alzheimer's disease and mild cognitive impairment. This initiative is especially timely and relevant in contexts where access to advanced neuroimaging is limited.

My previous work on the Vietnamese adaptation of the Montreal Cognitive Assessment (MoCA), along with ongoing collaborations with Vietnamese researchers, has underscored the importance of accessible, culturally sensitive diagnostic methods. I will contribute to this project through my expertise in neuropsychological assessment design, clinical interpretation, and the adaptation of tools to ensure both cultural relevance and clinical applicability.

Furthermore, I will offer guidance on methodology, validation strategies, and data interpretation, drawing on my experience in cross-cultural research and international collaborations.

Following in-depth discussions with Dr Ha, we strongly believe that this project will make a meaningful contribution to the early detection and management of neurodegenerative diseases, ultimately improving outcomes and quality of life for individuals affected by dementia.

Please do not hesitate to contact me should you require any further information.

Sincerely,

Dr Halle Quang
Postdoctoral Research Fellow
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The University of Sydney
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